

Production Buddy

Capabilities Breakdown — what each function actually does

v1.0.12

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Overview

This document lists every capability Production Buddy ships with, grouped by function. Each entry gives a one-line description, a note on when to use it, and the specific things it can do. Use this as a reference when deciding which features to enable for a given job.

A. Markup → Edits engine

What: Reads PDF reviewer comments and applies them to the source InDesign/Illustrator file.

When to use: After a stakeholder review pass on a PDF.

Edit operations supported

- **Replace text** — strikethrough + sticky-note replacement, or a sticky note alone with new text
 - **Insert text** — caret annotations with a sticky note
 - **Delete text** — strikethrough alone (deletes just the marked text)
 - **Add table row** — annotated row appended to a target table
 - **Insert row at index** — new row at a specific position
 - **Delete row** — strikethrough on a row
 - **Sort table** — instruction-style annotation (“sort alphabetically”)
 - **Set cell value** — change one cell without disturbing the rest of the row
 - **Set cell fill / text color** — comments like “change this row to gray”, “make this header white”, or a CMYK / hex color spec are routed to the matching swatch (or created if missing)
 - **Set cell stroke** — “delete this border line” / “make this rule lighter”: the app resolves the annotation’s coords to the nearest table column or row edge and changes its weight/color
 - **Match text size to other fields** — a comment like “make this same size as the other fields” triggers an automatic resize: the app finds peer form-label paragraphs (short, colon-terminated) on the same page, reads their modal paragraph style, and applies that style to the target — fixing size, font, leading and color in one shot
 - **Relink image** — “swap this logo for <name>”: the app finds the placed graphic at the annotation coords and re-links it to the named asset from the Reference files folder
 - **Delete page**
 - **Append pages from another .indd** — extra assets the markup references
 - **Place asset into a frame** — drop a referenced image into the indicated frame
 - **Place asset on a new page**
 - **Human review escalation** — anything ambiguous lands in a human-review queue rather than guessing
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B. Hi-res image swap

What: Replaces watermarked stock-photo comps with their licensed hi-res equivalents.

When to use: Before final output if comps were placed during design.

What it does

- Extracts each placed image's stock-photo numeric ID (Getty, Adobe Stock, Shutterstock)
 - Searches the supplied hi-res images folder for a matching file
 - Matches with or without an ICF_ filename prefix
 - Re-links the .indd entry; the original asset path is preserved as a comment in the run log
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C. Reference-file routing

What: Lets the markup reference external assets (a logo, a chart, a separate .indd) by name.

When to use: When the reviewer wrote “append the rebate sheet” or “place the new map here”.

Supported types: .indd, .pdf, .ai, .psd, raster images.

What happens automatically

- The app matches each annotation that mentions an asset to the right file
- Calls APPEND_PAGES_FROM_INDD, PLACE_ASSET_IN_FRAME, or PLACE_ASSET_NEW_PAGE as appropriate

D. Production QA checks

What: Reads the document after edits and flags production issues.

Auto-fixed silently (no action needed)

- Whitespace cleanup (multiple spaces, trailing spaces)
- Smart quotes (straight → typographic “ ” ‘ ’)
- Doubled punctuation (... → ..., doubled commas collapsed)
- ® / ™ / © superscripted

Errors (must fix before publish)

- Images below 300 dpi effective
- Missing linked assets
- Fonts not properly installed
- Overset text (text doesn't fit its frame)

Warnings (review and decide)

- Hyperlink text doesn't match destination
- Broken hyperlinks (4xx/5xx)
- Hyperlinks unreachable
- URL-like text without an active hyperlink
- Paragraph style overrides
- Paragraph color overrides
- Many distinct fonts (>4 by default)
- RGB swatches in a print doc
- Rich black on small text (≤14pt body)
- Hyphen used where en-dash likely intended
- Empty paragraphs (multiple consecutive returns)
- No bleed configured
- Linked assets out of date
- Possible spelling issues

Info inventory (FYI)

- Hyperlink count, image count, font list, spot colors, color profile, page dimensions, bleed settings, hidden layers with content, locked items, master-page overrides, overprint preferences

E. Section 508 compliance check

What: A separate pass triggered by the checkbox on tab 1.

What it checks

- Text/background color contrast $\geq 4.5:1$
 - All line weights $\geq 1\text{pt}$
 - Alt text on every placed image
 - Document metadata: title, author, subject, keywords
 - Forces “Create Tagged PDF” on export
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F. Brand-guide library

What: A persistent library of parsed brand guides. Tab 1 has a Brand Guide picker; saved guides live in the app’s userData folder and are matched automatically by filename on subsequent runs.

When to use: Whenever you want the QA pass to check colors and fonts against the official brand system, not just generic “is this RGB in a print doc” heuristics.

What it does

- Parses a brand-guide PDF for swatches (matched by name like DTE Blue, plus CMYK / RGB / hex values) and the family of fonts the guide uses
 - Saves the parsed result under ~/Library/Application Support/Production Buddy/brand-guides/<name>.json
 - On every subsequent .indd pick, scans the saved library and auto-loads any guide whose **name** appears as a substring of the .indd filename (case-insensitive)
 - If two or more saved guides match the filename, a picker modal lets you choose which one to apply
 - Manual brand-guide selection wins — picking a brand-guide PDF for the run skips auto-match
 - Edits to the library (add / edit / delete a saved guide) take effect on the very next pick — no app restart needed
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G. Auto-relink missing assets

What: When asset links are broken, scans Box folders for the named files and reconnects them.

Triggered by: “Auto-relink missing assets when found in Box” in Settings → Output behavior.

What happens: After relinking, the PDF is automatically re-exported.

H. Auto-activate missing fonts

What: When fonts are missing, instructs FontExplorer X Pro to activate them.

Triggered by: “Auto-activate missing fonts via FontExplorer X Pro” in Settings → Output behavior.

What happens: After activation, the PDF is re-exported with proper font rendering.

I. Batch Data Merge

What: Generates per-record .indd files from a tagged template + data.

When to use: When you have one design and N records (e.g. 50 US states) and need a deliverable for each.

What it does

- Auto-flattens Excel workbooks into a CSV (one row per sheet, headers from row 1)
 - Or accepts a pre-flattened CSV
 - Applies InDesign Data Merge against the template using the CSV
 - Per-record image folder support: matches files by record name, exposes them as an @image column for drag-and-drop placement
 - Writes one .indd per record, named <TemplateName>_<RecordName>.indd
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J. Tag a Template

What: Reverse of Data Merge — turns a one-record InDesign file into a tagged template.

When to use: When you only have a finished design for one state and need to extend the design to all 50.

What it does

- Reads the reference state's values from the supplied Excel files
 - Scans the .indd for those literal values
 - Replaces them with <<placeholder>> tokens matching the column names
 - Writes a tagged copy (or rewrites in place if no output path is given)
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K. Local AI classifier (Ollama, optional)

What: A small local language model that handles ambiguous markup the rule-based matcher can't.

When to use: When reviewer notes are conversational ("delete this print ads line", "add a check mark to the row above") rather than direct strikethroughs.

What it does

- Runs entirely on the local machine — no API keys, no subscription, no data leaves the computer
- Default model: llama3.1:8b (~5GB one-time download)
- Anything still ambiguous after Ollama lands in HUMAN_REVIEW for manual handling
- Optional — the app works without it; rule-based matcher handles common edits